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A Rich Heritage

INDIA IS AN ancient land unified by geography and tradition. Most Indian languages use the same word for yesterday and tomorrow, reflecting belief in life as an eternal cycle. Sceptics see this as the reason for contemporary India's failure in keeping pace with the times. 'No people whose word for "yesterday" is the same as their word for "tomorrow" can be said to have a firm grip on the time,' author Salman Rushdie observed acerbically in his novel, *Midnight's Children*.[1] Others argue that India's rich heritage keeps it going even if it is not up to par with the world's currently developed nations. As politician and author Shashi Tharoor put it, 'India is not, as people keep calling it, an underdeveloped country, but rather, in the context of its history and cultural heritage, a highly developed one in an advanced state of decay.'[2]

Five thousand years of continuous civilization nurtured in the vast space between the Himalayas to the north, the Indian Ocean in the south and the Hindu Kush and Arakan mountains in the west and east has bred a sense of Indian exceptionalism. Others might judge the modern Indian state by its economic indicators, its low ranking on the human development index, or its apparent political and social chaos. For Indians, however, the Indian subcontinent represents one civilization and one indivisible historic entity,